

Tao Te Ching (道德经)

Laozi (老子) · Translated by James Legge (1891)

Chapter 1 — 第一章

原文 (ORIGINAL CHINESE)

道可道，非常道。名可名，非常名。

无名天地之始，有名万物之母。

故常无欲，以观其妙；常有欲，以观其徼。

此两者，同出而异名，同谓之玄。玄之又玄，众妙之门。

TRANSLATION

1. The Tao that can be trodden is not the enduring and unchanging Tao. The name that can be named is not the enduring and unchanging name.

2. (Conceived of as) having no name, it is the Originator of heaven and earth; (conceived of as) having a name, it is the Mother of all things.

3. Always without desire we must be found,
If its deep mystery we would sound;
But if desire always within us be,
Its outer fringe is all that we shall see.

4. Under these two aspects, it is really the same; but as development takes place, it receives the different names. Together we call them the Mystery. Where the Mystery is the deepest is the gate of all that is subtle and wonderful.

Translator's text from James Legge, "The Tao Teh King," in *The Texts of Taoism, Sacred Books of the East*, vol. 39 (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1891). This translation is in the public domain.